



Road to Victory

Per Capita GSDP Rs 23,786 which is above the national average

Infant Mortality Rate (per 1000) 30 against an All India figure of 60 (2007 Census)

Teacher-Pupil Ratio 1:18 against 1:34 of All India (2004-05)

The Prime Minister's Rozgar Yojana Rural artisans and small-scale entrepreneurs are trained by the Government in four districts

Investment In 15 years, the Government has invested over Rs 30,000 crore in core sectors like tourism, agriculture, horticulture and floriculture

State Revenue The state revenue as of now is Rs 600 crore. When the SDF took over in 1994, the state revenue was Rs 44 crore

Chamling in 1994, forged a strange ragtag alliance of the Congress, the BJP and the communists, perhaps the only one of its kind in the country. He drew crowds but the masses have now understood that this was the old, wily Bhandari at play—bringing truckloads of people from outside the state,

people who would not even be seen in the vicinity after the elections were over. In addition, Congress General Secretary Rahul Gandhi's visit just before the state went for elections on April 30, helped Bhandari's cause for a while as his rallies saw huge attendance. Despite the pomp and

show, it could not save the day for Bhandari who went on to lose two of his seats by 1,268 and 2,100 votes respectively, a significant margin in a thinly-populated state. Chamling, on his part, contested from two seats too but ensured that 10 of his rivals lost their deposits.

What sets Chamling apart is the fact that he is one of those rare politicians who have lived up to the people's expectations, delivering on the promises he made. Sample this: Chamling has brought 15 pharma units and 19 hydroelectricity projects to the state. By July, 11 five-star hotels are to be inaugurated, debunking Bhandari's claim that the state Government has not done anything to tap the most vital of all industries—tourism. The per capita income in Sikkim has risen to Rs 35,000 in the last decade, the highest in eastern India. And if this wasn't enough, the SDF Government has achieved a literacy rate of 82 per cent (see box).

It hasn't been a fairytale journey for the Sikkim chief minister, who was Bhandari's information minister before he was accused of anti-party activities and expelled in 1993. He has also been accused of having dual citizenship of Nepal and India. Chamling refuses to get provoked but that doesn't stop him from saying, "Yes, they are saying such things. But why should a chief minister even want to have dual citizenship? Ask them to explain that first."

In the long run, it is his connect with the people which has paid rich dividends to Chamling. Stories are rife about how he knows every family in his native south Sikkim areas by name. His record success hasn't yet gone to his head. "Till now, I have survived because I have worked for the people. The day they feel I am failing, they will not think twice before throwing me out. That is why I keep on trying. I would hate to lose the confidence of the people and fail to realise the dream of merging Sikkim with the mainstream life of India," he says. Sounds rather humble for someone who has achieved many a milestone in his political career. ■

RAHUL GANDHI



EVEN RAHUL GANDHI'S CHARISMA DID NOT WORK IN THE STATE AS THE CONGRESS FAILED TO WIN EVEN ONE SEAT.